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Suppose you say, “Find me a good laptop.” What does “good” mean? Good for gaming? Coding? College? Video editing? Battery life? Typing? Hindi content creation? Under ₹50,000? Available in India? With service centres nearby? with upgradeable RAM? A chatbot may give general advice. An agent may go and compare irrelevant products.

This is why agent-ready prompts reduce guessing. They define the goal, context, data, limits, approval points and final output. The better the brief, the better the agent behaves.



The CLEAR Framework

Use the CLEAR Framework whenever you want an agent to do something useful.

C: Context

Tell the agent what the situation is. Who is the task for? Why does it matter? What background information should it use?

L: Limits

Define what the agent must not do. Should it avoid paid tools? Should it avoid outdated sources? Should it not send messages, make payments, delete files or publish anything?

E: Expected Output

Specify the format. Do you want a table, checklist, email draft, comparison, summary, schedule, slide outline, code file or action plan?

A: Approval Points

Tell the agent when to stop and ask. For example: “Create the shortlist first. Do not draft the final email until I approve the direction.”

R: Review Method

Ask the agent to verify its own work. It can list assumptions, cite sources, flag uncertainty, show calculations, or create a final checklist.

This framework turns a casual request into a controlled workflow.

Bad prompt, better prompt

Bad prompt:

“Help me prepare for my interview.”

Better prompt:

“Act as an interview research assistant. I have to interview the India head of a semiconductor equipment company for a technology magazine. Create 12 sharp questions for a senior editorial audience. Focus on India’s semiconductor manufacturing ambitions, talent, supply chain, AI compute demand and local R&D. Avoid generic questions. Give one-line rationale for each question.”

The second prompt works because it gives role, context, audience, topic boundaries, desired count, quality expectation and output format.

Bad prompt:

“Summarise this PDF.”

Better prompt:

“Summarise this PDF for a non-technical business reader. First give a 150-word overview, then list 10 key takeaways, 5 risks, 5 numbers worth highlighting, and 6 possible article angles. Do not invent facts. If the PDF does not mention something, say so.”

The second prompt does not merely ask for a summary. It defines how the information should be used.

Step-by-Step: Build your first agent prompt

Step 1: Write the raw request

Start naturally. For example: “I need help planning a family trip to Kerala.”

Step 2: Add the outcome

What should exist at the end? “Create a four-day itinerary with hotel area suggestions, travel times, estimated cost and food options.”

Step 3: Add personal context

“Family of four, travelling from Mumbai, budget ₹80,000, vegetarian food preferred, parents cannot walk long distances.”

Step 4: Add constraints

“Do not include risky adventure activities. Avoid very expensive resorts. Do not book anything.”

Step 5: Add tools

“You may browse for current travel times and attraction timings. Use only credible travel or official sources where possible.”